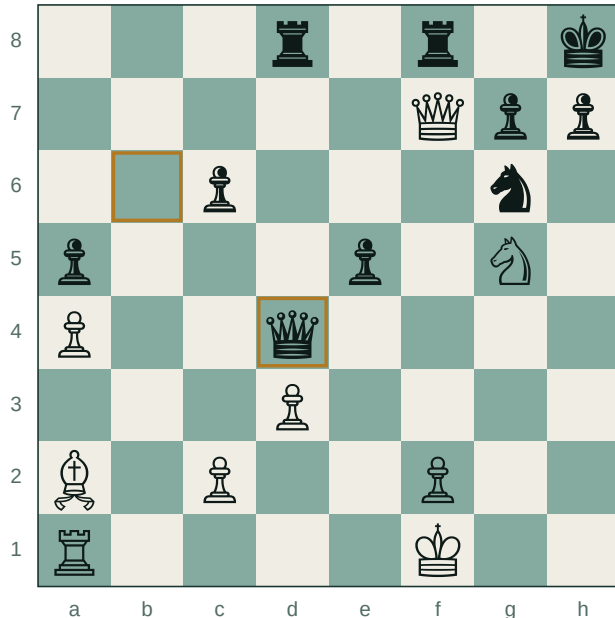


Smothered mates: White, move 26

Smothered mates

White to move



Previous move: 25...Qxd4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26. Qg8+ Rxd8 27. Nf7#

26.Qg8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From g8 it attacks king on h8 and rook on f8. Recorded reply: **26...Rxd8**.

27.Nf7# Mate: knight on f7 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Knight on f7. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A familiar pattern is insufficient if the knight can be captured. Verify protection and every legal king move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A knight can check a king surrounded by its own pieces. Those pieces become a cage because a knight check cannot be blocked.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace the knight's route to the checking square and identify the enemy pieces that deny the king its escape squares.

The defending king is on h8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.